Takeaways

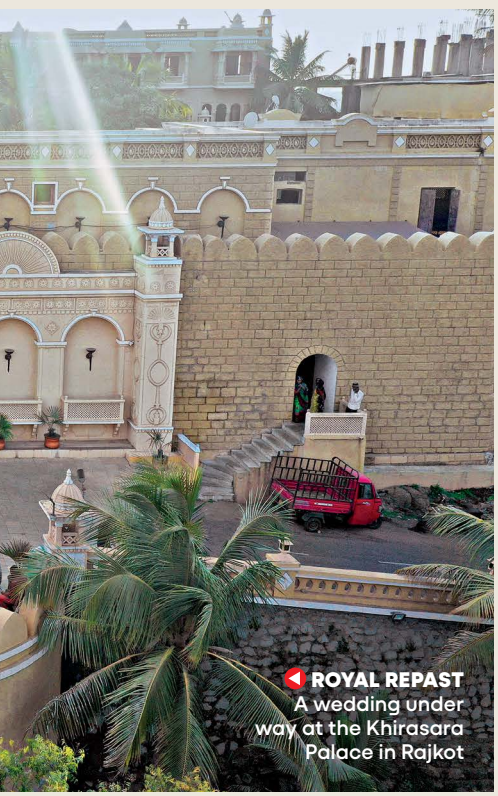
- **Eight senior IPS officers, including two of DGP rank, remain without active duty**
- **TDP cites abuse of power under YSRCP regime; Oppn alleges vendetta politics**

Senior IPS officers such as P. Sitharama Anjaneyulu, ex-CM Jagan Mohan Reddy's intelligence chief, and N. Sanjay, the state CID head when Naidu was arrested in 2023 in the alleged skill development project scam, were in remand for some time last year. They are out on bail now, but face action in a number of cases.

Another former state CID chief, P.V. Sunil Kumar, is facing an investigation in a 2021 case involving the alleged custodial torture of then rebel YSRCP MP and current Telugu Desam MLA and deputy speaker, Raghu Rama Krishna Raju. In February, the government extended his suspension till June 30, the day he superannuates. Anjaneyulu, due to retire in August, could face a similar fate; his April 2025 incarceration was related to a controversial 'illegal' arrest of a model-actress and her parents and alleged irregularities in evaluations in a public service examination.

So, is Naidu justified in his actions against the IPS men? A former state DGP doesn't mince words while also pointing out that elected governments retain their prerogative to withhold postings. "Political pressure is always there, but as IPS officers we must uphold the dignity and authority of the office," he says. Serving officers point to a more workday consequence to the case of their missing colleagues: a stretched force, which has to absorb the additional workload. ■

market analyst Grand View Research, this economy was pegged at Rs 1.73 lakh crore in 2025 across India, and is expected to reach Rs 4.6 lakh crore by 2033, at an annual growth rate of 14.8 per cent. Destination weddings involve a ticket size of anywhere between Rs 30 lakh and Rs 25 crore—not including the gifts, jewellery and trousseau. Though a dominant tourism player, Gujarat is a footnote in this sector currently. Goa and Rajasthan are the top two destinations for their beaches and heritage palaces respectively, followed by Uttar Pradesh, Kerala and Maharashtra.



ROYAL REPAST A wedding under way at the Khirasara Palace in Rajkot

SETTING UP SHOP

The first step in setting up its own shop, says Arya, is to identify 10-15 locations, and develop them with the specific requirements of the sector. A consultant is being onboarded for this. Some identified venues include the Statue of Unity in central Gujarat, the coastal town of Madhavpur Ghed near Porbandar (identified with the epic narrative of the Lord Krishna-Rukmini marriage), the White Rann of Kutch, and the coastal and pilgrimage towns of Dwarka-Shivrajpur, Ambaji and Somnath.

"We have grand heritage properties and palaces unique to Gujarat that are unlike those in Rajasthan," says Arya. "Luxurious stay and event hosting infrastructure already exists. But as we look to leverage our cultural heritage, we plan to create curated experiences and market them to event organisers and wedding planners."

The concept of marketing these destinations resonates well with Shraddha Rana, director at Heritage Khirasara Palace, a restored 27-room palace on the outskirts of Rajkot. "Post-COVID, there has been a boom in cosy destination weddings. We get a lot of inquiries from NRIs and high-spending locals. But to get non-Gujaratis to come here, the biggest hurdle are the prohibition laws. If there is a policy shift allowing group permission for destination weddings, we can tap into this potential," he says.

Takeaways

- **'Wed in Gujarat' initiative looks to tap into Rs 1.7 lakh cr. destination wedding economy**
- **Also wants to reverse trend of locals preferring locations outside state for their nuptials**

Anil Mulchandani, a travel writer and advisor to the Heritage Tourism Association of Gujarat, says the state has 35-40 heritage hotels and another 30-odd families are planning to renovate their properties. "A destination wedding needs 150-200 rooms for guests and another 100 for staff and services. This will be a huge ask for struggling heritage properties....The project can develop as a long-term vision, though, if the correct policies are in place," he says. ■